command level and HQ Integrated Defence Staff, the posting of officers representing the MOD, MEA, finance ministry and the Defence Research and Development Organization should also be implemented simultaneously. As an interim measure, the CISC could be upgraded to a vice chief of defence staff of four-star rank to oversee the transformation and restructuring of the armed forces. Alternatively, we could consider having a permanent chairman of COSC at four-star level with specific responsibilities as being advocated by Lieutenant General V.R. Raghavan, who is a member of the Naresh Chandra Committee that is looking at higher defence set-up and national security issues. However, neither of these iterim proposals, if adopted, should get enshrined as a permanent arrangement.

It would be fair to surmise that we could have a CDS by 2020, who should be vested with operational command of the three services and be of a five-star rank. He would then be an effective and meaningful ‘single-point’ adviser on defence matters.